

Reform Without Reframe: An NLP study of Femicide Discourse in Italian Newspapers

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Abstract

This study examines how Italian media discourse on femicide evolved alongside the adoption of the *Codice Rosso* (2019), a law aimed at prioritizing responses to gender-based violence through faster procedures and harsher penalties. Grounded in feminist media theory and a view of discourse as both a cultural artefact and a vehicle of power, we combine computational methods to interrogate the narrative and grammatical structures through which gender-based violence is made visible, or not. Rather than assume media as neutral intermediaries, we treat them as political institutions embedded in editorial, ideological, and algorithmic economies. This approach allows us to ask whether and how language shifts in tandem with other institutional changes. What emerges is not a discursive rupture, but a reconfiguration of silencing: the *Codice Rosso* entered the media lexicon, yet the narrative forms that depoliticize violence largely endured. Perpetrators remain peripheral, structural critique is rare, and femicide is normalized through procedural framings.

Introduction

Femicide, defined as “the killing of a woman by an intimate partner and the death of a woman as a result of a practice that is harmful to women” [7] represents one of the most extreme and visible forms of gender-based violence. Feminist scholarship has long emphasized that femicide must be understood not as a series of isolated acts, but as “a manifestation of the historical imbalance between the sexes” [8]. This structural perspective is particularly urgent in the Italian context, where, despite growing public outrage and recent waves of institutional reform, cases of femicide continue to occur with alarming regularity. In the first five months of 2025, at least 37 women have been killed by men in Italy — most by current or former partners [15]. In light of this, our paper investigates how the persistent tragedy of femicide is framed and absorbed by public discourse.

Media framing shapes public perceptions and social norms [6], as people’s understanding of an event is raised first through exposure to news coverage. Existing research has provided detailed explanations of how femicide is portrayed in the media discourse, showing that coverage of violence against women (VaW) often misrepresent the phenomenon and

reinforce broader gendered attitudes [9]. Femicide is rarely framed as a human rights issue or part of a pattern of structural violence [3]. Such narratives are not inconsequential: they shape how societies interpret violence and function as a crucial mechanism through which institutional change is demanded and interpreted [1] [6].

But what happens when such change takes place? Legal reforms often emerge from sustained public attention, social movement pressure, and shifting cultural norms [11] [19]. As such, media discourse and legal change may evolve together as institutions shaped by broader societal transformations of how VaW is understood and responded to. While some studies have qualitatively examined the representation of VaW in Italian media over time [4], limited empirical research exist assessing whether femicide discourse shifted during periods marked by legal reform.

This study addresses that gap by examining how public discourse evolved alongside a moment of heightened legal attention, as part of a broader socio-symbolic landscape of legal and narrative transformations. By combining computational methods with a feminist theoretical lens, our

research contributes to debates in feminist media theory about the relationship between symbolic representation and structural change. Understanding these discursive shifts, or the lack thereof, is essential to assessing the cultural efficacy of legal reforms meant to protect women's lives.

In 2019, the Italian Parliament passed Law No. 69, known as the *Codice Rosso*, which introduced fast-track procedures for reporting gender-based violence, created new legal categories such as revenge porn, and increased penalties for domestic abuse [13]. Although not explicitly centered on femicide, the law can be considered a significant step forward in the fight against VaW, though its impact remains understudied. It offers a strategic chronological anchor to investigate whether media narratives around femicide shifted alongside this institutional momentum.

To explore this, we draw on the FMNews dataset on Italian femicide news coverage developed and presented by Cappuccio et al. [5]. While their work provides valuable descriptive insights into keyword patterns and semantic associations, our study adds a longitudinal and interpretive dimension by examining whether framing patterns in the press changed in the years surrounding the *Codice Rosso*.

Theoretical Framework and Hypothesis

To investigate the relationship between femicide narratives and institutional reforms, we draw on theories of media framing, feminist linguistic analysis, and critical discourse studies. These approaches offer distinct but complementary perspectives on how VaW is constructed in language and meaning — whether it is treated as a structural issue, how agency is distributed through grammar, and the affective tones used to present it.

1. Depoliticised framing

Freeland et al. [4] observe that media representations of femicide often reflect an ambivalence toward naming the structural inequalities that enable violence, presenting murders as isolated or

anomalous events. Structural patterns and root causes are largely absent from mainstream narratives [3] [10], which deprives femicide of its broader social and political meaning. Instead of framing killings as a symptom of gendered power relations, media often depict them as tragic, yet apolitical, occurrences. If, as framing theory suggests [6], legal reforms can introduce new interpretive frameworks into public discourse, we might expect media narratives to shift accordingly. This leads to the following hypothesis:

H1: *Femicide coverage in Italian media has become more structurally contextualised, and less depoliticised, since the introduction of the Codice Rosso.*

2. Attribution of agency

Feminist linguistic analysis has long stressed how grammar encodes responsibility. In the context of femicide, Minnema et al. [14] find that Italian media frequently use passive and impersonal constructions with phrases like “she was killed” or “there was a homicide” which obscure or entirely erase the perpetrator. This syntactic pattern contributes to a broader tendency to de-agentify male violence and deflect accountability. If the *Codice Rosso* reflected a discursive shift in how institutions frame gender violence, our hypothesis would be that:

H2: *Since the introduction of the Codice Rosso, femicide reporting in Italian media has shifted toward more explicit grammatical constructions that assign agency to perpetrators.*

3. Sensationalism and emotional tone

Several studies argue that media often adopt sensationalistic framings of femicide, emphasizing shock, tragedy, or horror over explanation and context. Freeland et al. [9] highlight how emotionally saturated language can dramatize violence while sidelining structural critique. This aligns with Aldrete and Fernández-Ardèvol's [1] observation that such language often results in “episodic” framings, those that prioritize immediate emotional reaction over systemic understanding. If the *Codice Rosso* signaled

lgreater commitment, we hypothesise that:

H3: *Since the introduction of the Codice Rosso, the use of spectacularizing and emotionally charged language in Italian femicide coverage has decreased.*

Methodology

To assess how Italian media discourse around femicide has evolved along the introduction of *Codice Rosso*, we apply comparative methods from Natural Language Processing (NLP). Our study conceptualizes media language as both a reflection of and a contributor to cultural meaning-making [6]. Through NLP techniques, we quantify changes in framing by identifying lexical, grammatical, and emotional patterns across time.

We base our analysis on the FMNews-Nat corpus [5], a dataset of femicide-related articles published between 2009 and 2024 across six national newspapers with differing political orientations, which we do not disaggregate, as the focus of this study lies on broader patterns of media representation rather than outlet-specific variation. The full procedure for data extraction and cleaning is documented in the original FMNews dataset publication [5].

After we divided the corpus into pre-law and post-law subsets based on the enactment of the *Codice Rosso* (July 19, 2019), the final dataset included 11,580 articles: 3,128 published before the *Codice Rosso* and 7,643 after. All analyses were conducted in Python, and texts were processed with spaCy's Italian NLP pipeline for tokenization and lemmatization. These two temporal subsets form the basis for the comparative analyses presented in the following sections.

Keyword Frequency Analysis (TF-IDF-based)

Term Frequency–Inverse Document Frequency (TF-IDF) is first used to measure the relative salience of words across documents by balancing their

frequency within a text and their rarity across the corpus. TF-IDF helps assess whether Italian media coverage of femicide has become less depoliticized and more structurally contextualized following the introduction of the *Codice Rosso* (H1).

For this analysis only, we applied stopwords removal to reduce lexical noise. Rather than relying on spaCy's default Italian stopwords list, we adapted a manually curated version sourced from a public GitHub repository [15].

Building on feminist media research that distinguishes between individualized and systemic framings of gender violence [1] [9], we apply TF-IDF vectorization separately to pre- and post-law corpora. To operationalize this method, we extracted the top 100 TF-IDF keywords from each period and categorized subsets into two interpretive frames containing 22 tokens each:

(1) **Structural keywords**, including references to systemic issues, legal institutions, or political actors (*"patriarchy"*, *"law"*, *"society"*);

(2) **Depoliticised keywords**, which emphasize domesticity, personal ties, or emotive details (*"family"*, *"son"*, *"relationship"*).

We then calculated the normalized frequency of each keyword group and performed two-tailed t-tests to assess the statistical significance of observed shifts.

Results

Articles published after the *Codice Rosso* use structural keywords less frequently, dropping from approximately 2.0% to 1.6% of total words, while depoliticized keywords rise from 2.4% to just over 3% (Figure 1). The shift is statistically robust, with two-tailed t-tests yielding $p < 0.0001$ in both cases (Table 1). The consistent increase in depoliticized framing suggests that, contrary to our hypothesis, the discourse has not moved toward greater structural contextualization following the reform. Instead, media representations appear to have further individualized and privatized the narrative of femicide.

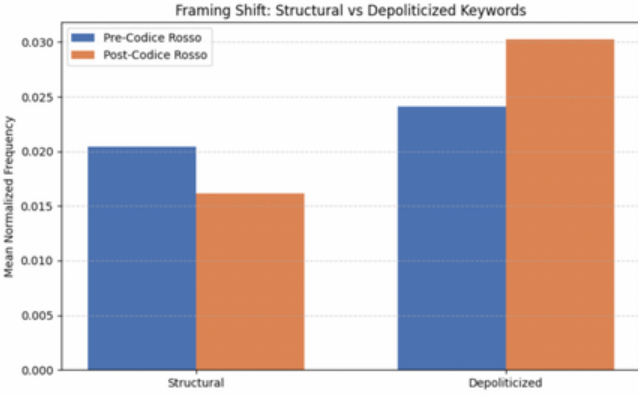


Figure 1: Mean normalized frequency of structural vs. depoliticized keywords in femicide reporting before and after the Codice Rosso.

Framing Shift Summary				
Frame Type	Pre Mean	Post Mean	Direction	p-value (t-test)
0 Structural	0.02044	0.01614	↓ slight decrease	0.0000 (significant)
1 Depoliticized	0.02408	0.03029	↑ increase	0.0000 (significant)

Table 1: Summary of shifts in structural and depoliticized keyword usage before and after the Codice Rosso, with direction and statistical significance.

Syntactic Frame Analysis

Syntactic frame analysis evaluates how events are grammatically framed in media discourse, particularly in the attribution or suppression of agency [14]. This technique allows us to test whether Italian news coverage of femicide shifted toward more agentive framing following the *Codice Rosso* (H2). While Minnema et al. [14] employ a neural frame-semantic parser, we replicate their analytical logic using open-source NLP tools and rule-based syntactic modeling. We identify four event-based frames: Killing, Death, Cause_Harm, and Event, adapted from the framework developed by Minnema et al. [14], which maps grammatical patterns to the perceived distribution of agency in narratives of VaW. These capture how violence is linguistically constructed: whether it is framed as a deliberate act, a neutral occurrence, or an anonymized event. Their original study provides detailed examples for each frame, which informed our operationalisation [14]. To detect syntactic framing, we define three

grammatical constructions that capture degrees of agency:

- (1) **verbal:active**, where the grammatical subject is either a known perpetrator or a masculine reference (e.g., *the partner*);
- (2) **verbal:passive**, where the subject is the victim and the perpetrator is omitted or backgrounded;
- (3) **verbal:impersonal**, where the agent is fully erased using impersonal expressions (e.g., *there was a homicide*).

For every article in the dataset, we identify co-occurrences between frame-relevant verbs and syntactic structures. They are processed using spaCy's syntactic dependency custom parser (*it_core_news_sm* model). Verbs are lemmatized to ensure that different conjugations could be matched to frame definitions. Results are aggregated to compute the frequency of each frame–syntax pairing, and normalized to allow proportional comparison.

Results

The Killing frame—referring to sentences describing how the perpetrator killed its victim [14]—remains predominantly encoded in passive and impersonal syntax in both periods (Table 2). Active constructions, which would explicitly identify the killer as the subject, rise only modestly from 1.29% pre- to 2.22% post-*Codice Rosso*, despite this increase being statistically significant ($p = 0.009$). In contrast, passive constructions maintain their dominance at over 21%, with no significant reduction after the law's enactment ($p = 0.647$).

A similar pattern emerges in the Cause_Harm frame, representing descriptions of how the perpetrator caused its victim to be hurt [14]. Although active syntactic framing increases from 0.45% to 1.35% ($p = 0.001$), it remains the least used. The overall imbalance across frames shows that active constructions are consistently marginal, while passive ones constitute the dominant form of grammatical encoding, followed closely by impersonal constructions.

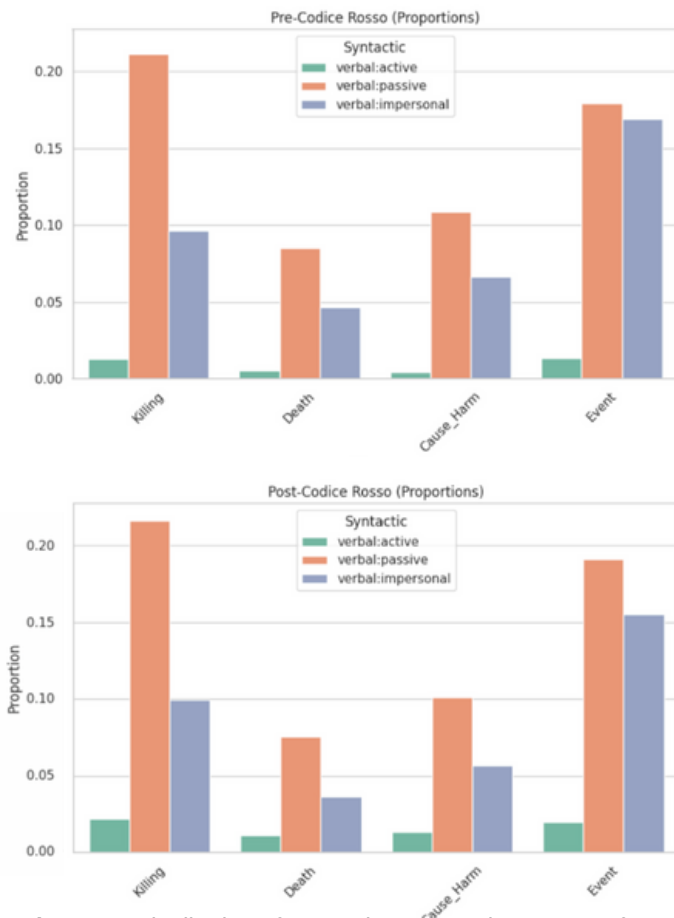


Figure 2: Distribution of syntactic constructions across four event-based frames in femicide news coverage before and after the Codice Rosso.

Sentiment Analysis

Sentiment analysis is used to detect the emotional tone or polarity of textual data [2]. We adapt this technique to examine whether femicide coverage in Italian media has become less emotionally charged and sensationalist following the *Codice Rosso* (H3). Rather than relying on conventional polarity or emotion labels, we operationalize sentiment analysis through discursive categories grounded in feminist media theory [1]:

- (1) **emotional language** that frames femicide as an intimate tragedy, emphasizing biographical details, emotional loss, and relational roles;
- (2) **sensationalisation of violence** that dramatizes the act through graphic or horror-like detail, exaggerated descriptors that accentuate violence.

These registers function as key discursive mechanisms in the mediatisation of gender violence, often displacing structural critique [1]. To capture such nuanced forms of affect, we use a Large Language Model (ChatGPT-4o), which allows for more context-sensitive sentiment assessment than traditional lexicon-based approaches [2].

Each article is scored on a 0–3 scale for the presence of (1) emotional and (2) sensationalistic language using structured prompts developed from the literature (see *Appendix II*). We calculate the mean score for each category and apply statistical tests (Welch’s t-test) to assess whether the observed differences are significant. To triangulate these results, we conduct a reading of five randomly selected articles from each period, identifying representative textual extracts that qualitatively support the quantitative trends.

Results

As shown in Figures 3 and 4, both forms of affective intensity decline significantly after the legal reform. On a 0–3 scale, average score drops from 2.00 to 1.00 for both emotional and sensationalistic language. In both cases, Welch’s t-tests confirm statistical significance ($t \approx 79.7$, $p < .001$).

These results, suggesting a measurable discursive shift toward more neutral framings of femicide in Italian media since the introduction of the *Codice Rosso*, support our hypothesis. Our qualitative triangulation further reinforce these findings, revealing consistent textual shifts that enrich our understanding of how emotional and sensational framings have changed.

Before 2019, victims were humanized through biographical framing while community mourning was explicitly evoked. For an article LLM scored 3 for sensationalistic language, we confirm spectacle was frequently mobilized through graphic and hyperbolic language: “He stabbed her to death in front of the eyes of their 5-year-old child, striking her and leaving her agonizingly on the seat, with the little one in tears” [12]. Post-2019 articles show a marked reduction in both dimensions. Emotional expressions often remain, but they tend to take indirect or

symbolic forms, for instance when describing the commemoration for victims, rather than personal narratives. Sensationalist tones show a similar tendency: while headlines may still hint at drama, main texts emphasize procedural developments.

Discussion

Confronted with alarming numbers of femicides in Italy [15], our study investigates whether the media's discursive framing evolved alongside institutional efforts to address VaW, given their long-recognized responsibility in translating this systemic issue in public discourse [1] [17]. Our NLP analysis of the FMNews-Nat dataset [5] helps uncover new trends after the introduction of the *Codice Rosso*, revealing changes that do not yet align with the structural and agentive reframing long demanded by feminist scholars and advocacy groups [3] [9].

Across all levels of analysis, we find that Italian news coverage absorbed the legal shift without fundamentally transforming the grammar, tone, nor narrative structure through which femicide is translated to the public. The results of our TF-IDF keyword frequency analysis indicate that *Codice Rosso* did not enter discourses as a lens to recontextualize femicide within its structural and political dimensions. The law's symbolic weight did not trigger an epistemic shift; instead, femicide continues to be framed episodically, as a recurring anomaly rather than a manifestation of patriarchy [1].

Moreover, our sentiment analysis reveals a transition from emotional and spectacular registers that once dominated articles [4], to procedural tones after the *Codice Rosso*. On the surface, this may appear to support our initial hypothesis that legal recognition would lead to more neutral and sober reporting. However, this neutrality does not automatically signal progress. In the absence of corresponding structural or grammatical shifts (H1-H2), a more "neutral" tone risks muting the political substance of femicide rather than clarifying it. When discourse is stripped of politicization and agency, it is less likely to mobilize change, making femicides a "normalized" entry in the news cycle, *faits divers*¹ stripped of politics, reproduced through the symbolic violence of dismissive language.

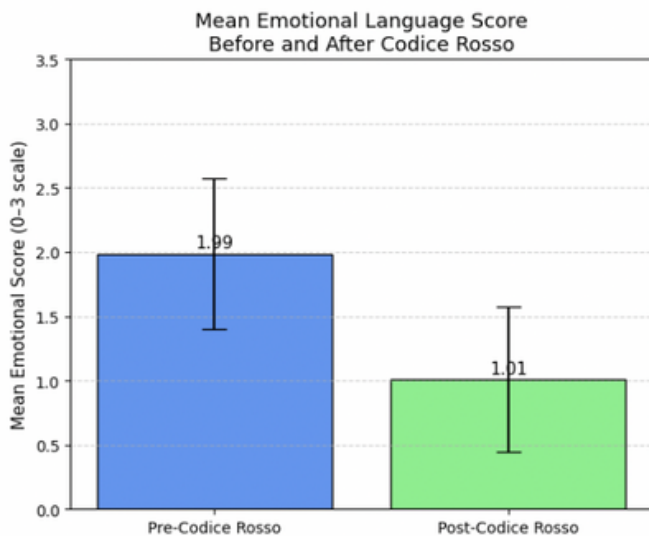


Figure 3: Mean emotional language score in femicide news coverage before and after the introduction of *Codice Rosso*.

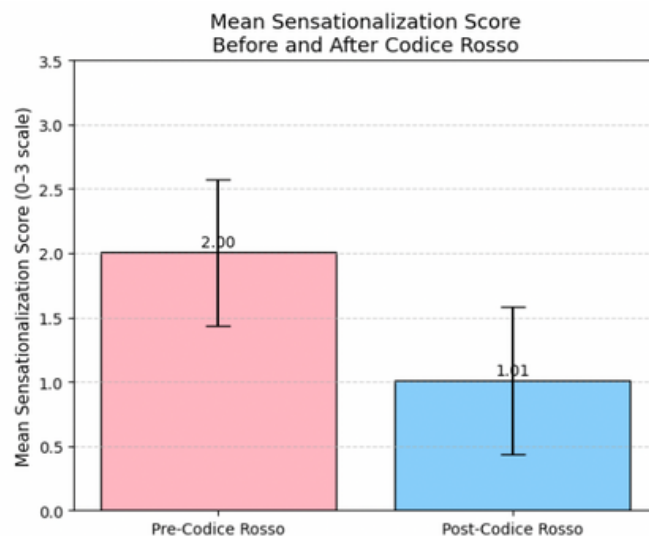


Figure 4: Mean sensationalisation score in femicide news coverage before and after the introduction of *Codice Rosso*.

¹ In French newspapers, the *faits divers* section specifically refers to short, sensational, often crime-related stories found in a "general interest section" — such as accidents, murders, or unusual events. It is often discussed as a genre that depoliticizes or individualizes structural issues.

However, rudimentary progress in media's framing of femicides in Italy, following pressures from feminist advocacy groups [4] [9], has been noticed in the syntactic structure of news coverage. We observe a statistically significant increase in referencing perpetrators when describing the act of killing and the cause of harm. Despite the marginal rise, active phrasing remains rare, as the subject of the sentence for both categories remains the victim considerably more than the killer. In order for Italian newspapers to contribute to the eradication of VaW alongside legal reform, efforts must be made to recenter the narrative around the perpetrators, departing from their long history of victim blaming [4] [9].

This study has limitations. Our sentiment analysis relied on a large language model (ChatGPT), which, despite its capacity for context-sensitive evaluation, introduces opacity and potential classification errors. While we validated its outputs through limited human cross-checking, we did not perform full-scale manual coding, which constrains the **interpretability** and replicability of our results. In light of the other methods, these considerations do not discard our argument that media framing is shifting toward a normalisation of femicides, failing to reflect the broader social changes that led to the introduction of the *Codice Rosso*.

Conclusion

One of the most revealing outcomes of our analysis is the disjunction between legal and discursive change. The *Codice Rosso* aimed at tackling gender-based violence with maximum priority, but this has not been mirrored by radical transformation in how femicide is represented through media framing. If law and language are both sites of cultural meaning-making, their misalignment signals the limits of institutional change when symbolic discourse does not evolve in tandem.

The increasing neutrality shown by our analysis might appear as a logical continuity of journalistic—capitalistic—norms, which glorify brevity, event-focus,

and emotional resonance without structural depth. Yet this tendency is likely to intensify as news production continues to adapt to social media logics and AI-driven content, where speed, visibility, and algorithmic ranking outweigh discursive nuance.

In an environment where headlines are often the only part of a story users read and share, we suggest future research should focus more critically on the linguistic framing of headlines themselves.

Moreover, what may appear as neutrality in media discourse invisibilizes power relations and dilutes accountability. Language is a political device [18], and this becomes evident in the continued preference for depoliticized-over-structural framings, or in the limited grammatical shifts that place responsibility on perpetrators as shown by our analysis. Therefore, media could never adopt an unpolitical stance in the face of a violence that our discussion proves to be political, as every article is a result of choices about whose actions are visible, whose suffering is narrativized, and whose power remains unspoken. We thus consider the rise of neutrality observed another way of refusing to name power.

Ultimately, the media cannot be yet understood as institutional proxies of societal changes in VaW representation in Italy. They are themselves products of power, shaped by political cultures, editorial constraints, and ideological filters—more than often rooted in patriarchy. This inertia may reflect a broader reluctance to politicize VaW in ways that challenge hegemonic norms, such as the continued disregard for framing femicides as a human rights violation at the systemic level [3]. Future research could therefore investigate how the political orientation of news outlets shapes discursive choices, particularly when the political affiliations of newspapers are often explicit and widely acknowledged.

What emerges from our study is not simply the failure of journalistic language to change, but the limits of institutional reforms when they are not absorbed into public discourse. The symbolic power of *Codice*

Rosso lies not only in its legal provisions, but in whether it reshapes the collective imagination. That reshaping must begin with language. But here, language remained a vessel for the same silences it was meant to break.

Acknowledgements

We gratefully acknowledge the authors of the FMNews dataset [5] for granting us access to their corpus through a formal NDA agreement. Their work provided the empirical foundation of this study, and we thank them for their trust and support.

We also account for the use of OpenAI's ChatGPT-4o to assist with specific stages of our coding process, for generating code components for both batch processing in our syntactic frame analysis and computing summary tables of statistical test results on Python. All outputs were reviewed, adapted, and interpreted by us with care to ensure methodological rigor and academic integrity.

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Appendices

Appendix I:

The code used for this analysis is available at: <https://github.com/reformwithoutreframe/Reform-Without-Reframe>

Appendix II:

Prompt 1 – Emotional language

Task: Analyze a collection of Italian newspaper articles reporting on femicide, grouped into two sets: articles published before the introduction of the Codice Rosso law (pre-2019) and articles published after (post-2019).

Objective: For each article, assign a score reflecting the presence and intensity of emotionally charged language that specifically evokes grief, loss, mourning, or that emphasizes the personal identity and humanity of the victim (e.g., age, family roles, life history, being “loved by all,” etc.).

Scoring Scale (per article):

- 0 = No emotional language
- 1 = Mild emotional language
- 2 = Moderate emotional language (present but not dominant)
- 3 = Strong and recurring emotional language (central to the narrative)

Instructions: Assign a score to each article based on the scale above.

Prompt 2 – Sensationalistic language

Task: Analyze a collection of Italian newspaper articles reporting on femicide, grouped into two sets: articles published before the introduction of the Codice Rosso law (pre-2019) and articles published after (post-2019).

Objective: For each article, assign a score reflecting the presence and intensity of sensationalized language, defined as journalistic language that dramatizes the act of femicide through graphic or horror-like detail, exaggerated or shocking descriptors, and narrative techniques that emphasize spectacle over structural context.

Scoring Scale (per article):

- 0 = No sensationalized language
- 1 = Mild presence (e.g., one isolated term or phrase)
- 2 = Moderate presence (more than one instance, but not dominant)
- 3 = Strong and recurring presence (sensationalism is central to the narrative)

Instructions: Assign a score to each article based on the scale above.

Peer Review Response

We would like to sincerely thank both reviewers for their thoughtful and constructive feedback, which significantly improved the clarity, coherence, and analytical strength of our final paper. Below we outline how we responded to the comments and suggestions provided.

Framing and Causality

A key suggestion from both reviewers concerned our causal framing: specifically, the need to avoid presenting the Codice Rosso as a direct cause of media change. We took this seriously and reshaped our theoretical framing. Instead of positioning media discourse as responsive to legal reform, we now frame both institutional and discursive shifts as potentially emerging from broader sociocultural transformations. We also revised our abstract accordingly to communicate this nuance upfront.

Clarifying Contributions and Implications

Reviewers asked a clearer articulation of the societal and scientific relevance of our findings.

In response, we adjusted the introduction to better show our study's contribution to feminist media theory, especially regarding the persistent depoliticization of femicide in news discourse. We also emphasized the societal implications, noting how framing choices shape public understanding and institutional accountability around gender-based violence.

Methodological Transparency and Limitations

We further addressed suggestions related to methodological clarity and acknowledgement of limitations. First, we reorganized the methodology section to better explain how data was parsed differently across methods. Stopword removal was moved to the TF-IDF method description, but the justification of what was missing from spaCy's default list and why those additions mattered could not be added due to word count. We clarified that this preprocessing step did not affect our syntactic analysis, as no stopwords were removed from that dataset. In response to concerns about the sentiment analysis using ChatGPT, we explicitly acknowledged its limitations in our conclusion, including the opacity of LLMs and the risk of classification error. While we performed limited manual validation through qualitative triangulation, we noted that we did not conduct full manual coding and framed our findings accordingly.

Dataset Description and Media Selection

Both reviewers requested more context about our dataset and media sources. Due to word count and copyright considerations, we now refer readers directly to the original FMNews dataset paper, where article selection and cleaning procedures are fully documented. We also clarified that while the dataset includes outlets with differing political orientations, this variable was not disaggregated in our analysis, as our aim was to trace general discursive patterns. We do, however, suggest this as an avenue for future research.

Results and Theory Integration

We expanded the results section of the third method

(sentiment analysis) to include both statistical outcomes and qualitative examples, helping readers interpret the findings more concretely. We also added a short introductory paragraph to the theoretical framework to better situate the concepts of grammar and emotional tone in relation to our broader argument.

Clarity and Style

Reviewer suggestions helped improve tone and clarity. We clarified phrases in the abstract to define the Codice Rosso early on, or replace “language became cleaner” with our own interpretations, and refined hypothesis phrasing for consistency.

We are grateful for the time, care, and insight our peer reviewers brought to this process, and we believe our paper is significantly stronger because of their input.